

Getting data from a source where anyone is allowed to submit essentially whatever they want is not generally going to be reliable. For example, I thought my data would be fairly clean if I simply removed all duplicates from the set. This did not end up being the case. Initially, I was getting results that simply made no sense. One of the GRE averages was higher than the maximum possible score, for example. I thought it might've been my code, but it turned out to that people had submitted numbers that were above the maximum possible score. I even found one specific example in my data of a 9.99 GPA!

Apart from the submitters being unreliable, the data is also not a random, representative sample of the general population. People using this website might tend to be online more often than your average applicant, or perhaps people are more inclined to post here when they are accepted, since it's a badge of accomplishment as opposed to a testament to literal rejection. I would not use this data to get a real understanding of the true general population.

The technical limitations of scraping the website (in the way that I did) also mean that the only data that shows up is the most recent. One of the questions I created was about the months with the highest volumes of posts. February had 17979, while June had a mere 29. Having data for such a short time scale makes it vulnerable to many more independent factors.